

The Glorious Tantra King of Great Power

Śrī Mahābala Tantra Rāja · Toh 391 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་སྒྲོམ་པ་ཆེ་བའི་རྒྱ་ཀླིང་པོ་

Toh 391 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Mahābala Tantra Rāja, in Tibetan as Dpal stobs po che'i rgyud kyi rgyal po (The Glorious Tantra King of Great Power), and in English as The Glorious King of Tantras of Great Power. It belongs to the class of Vajrayāna tantric texts and opens in the manner of a buddha-word sūtra, describing the Blessed One dwelling in meditative equipoise surrounded by an assembly of bodhisattvas, ḍākinīs, yoginīs, and māmos, pointing to its character as an esoteric teaching concerned with vows, the conquest of the six great enemies, and practices associated with wrathful and feminine tantric figures. The text proceeds in a mixture of verse and prose, situating it within the broader tradition of yoginī or mother tantras. It was translated into Tibetan by the monk-translator Śākya Ye shes and is preserved as Toh 391 in the Kangyur, among the tantric scriptures of that collection.

and was translated by the translator-monk Śākya Ye shes.

In the language of India: Śrī Mahābala Tantra Rāja nāma. In the Tibetan language: The Glorious Tantra King of Great Power. Homage to the Glorious Essence of Vows.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, dwelt in meditative equipoise within the bhaga of the consort, surrounded by an assembly of heroes such as the bodhisattva Vajragarbha and others, who had been blessed by all the Tathāgatas, together with an assembly of ḍākinīs such as the Lāmā and others, along with yoginīs and an assembly of māmos.

Renowned throughout the world,
the great enemies are six in number.
Just as when the sun has set,
the townspeople plunder
horses, elephants, and other goods,
stripping all things utterly away,
and all are left born into poverty —
so too, when the sun of wisdom sets
before the enemies of the six objects,
in the darkness of ignorance,
all ordinary beings are stripped of their wealth:

the five wisdoms and all that goes with them,
and they are born into a place devoid of joy.

In order to utterly vanquish those enemies,
there is no ritual offering, no recitation,
no tormā, no burnt offering, no maṇḍala,
no reading, no meditation, no dhyāna.

Abandoning altogether
distracted days and assemblies of stars,
seat yourself well upon a comfortable seat,
and polish wisdom and gnosis.

Like the wheel of a chariot,
the mind races rightly through its objects.

Drawing it back from those,
stir the great wind of karma.

Let the great fire of gnosis blaze,
burning away conceptual thought,
and filled with the taste of nectar
as though full of sesame seeds —
rest in the state beyond arising.

Then, when the mind has become stable,
appearance as a sign will cease.

Drawing back from that very state,
meditate on your own mind as empty.

When no-self in phenomena is realized,
at that point the mind itself is realized.
Filled everywhere with the taste of emptiness,
this is called the body of great bliss.

This is the Perfection of Wisdom.

In it there is nothing to be removed,
nothing whatsoever to be added.

Liberation comes from seeing suchness itself.

One family, three families,
five families, and a hundred families and more —
in this, suchness is not differentiated among them.
Just as one who has found an elephant

does not go seeking the elephant's tracks,
so when the suchness of mind is found,
no conceptual thought whatsoever need be sought.

Just as someone craving poison
is given medicine itself combined with poison,
and the poison arising from the medicine in that compound —
a skilled physician knows how to compound it.
So too with butter, molasses,
the essence of butter, and the like:
when drunk and dissolved, they become medicine.

In the same way, what I have taught
has interpretable meaning and definitive meaning,
literal and non-literal readings,
intentional and non-intentional senses.
Just as gold that has been burned, cut, and rubbed
on a touchstone — examine my words thoroughly,
and then accept them.
Do not follow them out of faith alone,
nor let another, however learned, simply impose their interpretation.

Just as a foolish person,
acting as an enemy,
gives poison disguised as medicine —
if one takes it, thinking it medicine and swallowing the poison,
one will die afterward.
Know that all methods are like illusion,
and wisdom is taught to be beyond expression.

Just as a learned physician
draws out poison with poison,
just as one burned by fire
must be treated with fire,
just as one overcome by great attachment
must abandon attachment through attachment itself,
just as one overcome by great aversion
must abandon aversion through aversion itself,
just as one overcome by great delusion

must abandon delusion through delusion itself —
for example, wind is the cause of a lamp's destruction.

That same wind becomes the ally of a forest fire.
Likewise, relying on desire is a domain of bliss.
By poison, one vanquishes enemies and attains non-duality.
Pills, eye-medicine, and the like —
all things arise from this very source.
Just as a skilled person on the far shore,
having relied on a raft to cross over,
reaches the other side and then abandons the raft —
so too, one who seeks self-awareness
relies on the illusory woman,
and thereby attains the primordial wisdom of self-awareness.
Once the primordial wisdom of self-awareness is attained,
the illusory woman is to be cast aside.

One who practices the profound conduct
without having understood the profound intent,
without having realized the profound intent,
will fall into the great hells.
Just as a person who slips from the peak of a mountain
suffers a tremendous fall,
so it is with such a one.

Furthermore, a silkworm binds itself
with its own thread.
A moth at night
burns itself in the flame.

Remaining in the mode of mere illusion,
and utterly free from the four extremes,
all conceptual elaboration is thoroughly stilled.
It is neither the object of expression nor the means of expression.
Abiding in the midst of all views,
this is the Perfection of Wisdom.

This concludes the first chapter, the chapter of direct realization, from the
tantra of the Glorious Mahāsthāmaprapta.

Now, as for the one who performs the examination: the place must be supremely praised. Upon a maṇḍala of one cubit, one applies with the five substances of the first kind, to the extent of a single finger-width. Then one smears it with great fragrance and fragrant water and strews blue flowers upon it. One adorns it beautifully with ornaments and the like. Five vases are placed at the four directions and the center. One then recites one hundred or one hundred thousand times, consecrating the nectar water. The person to be examined is first purified by bathing at the boundary. A black reversing garment is put on in reverse. The hair is bound upward, the flesh is bound, and a cloak is taken in hand; the person is stationed at the eastern door. A great lamp of fat-oil is placed to the east. To the west, a silver mirror and the like, pure. These are smeared with the five medicines and the five fragrances, and washed. Then, within the mirror, the signs of possessing spirits are to be examined. When the name of the possessing spirit and its mantra are appended at the end of the root mantra, all possessing spirits of gods and the like will appear as signs without doubt. The ornaments of that person vary, and the distinctions in seeing gods and the like become clear. As for the time, it is the day of the possessing spirits, the sun, and so on. When various signs appear, at that moment one brings the purpose under control. In order to remove possessing spirits and the like that harm life, merit, wealth, friends, and companions, one should also examine the particular ritual substances for auspicious ḍākinīs and the like, along with the ritual circles of offerings and feast offerings, by examining the signs. At the time of empowerment, primordial wisdom is also invoked. In the same way, one examines the signs of transgressions and the like in the pure mirror. And whatever other signs one wishes to examine, one must come to know them correctly from the mouth of the guru. In order to draw out the pain of illness, as taught in the medical science: wind, phlegm, bile, and their combination, together with the limbs — dwelling as four sites in the wheel of the body — after bathing the entire body, the mantra practitioner is to massage with the hand at the four sites. When examined in the center of the mirror, it is certain that wind and the like will be known. Thereafter one must know the medical treatment appropriate to that very wheel. As for the procedure of examining poison: for all limbs afflicted by illness, one examines the lymph nodes where the poison has entered. Then the medical treatment is to be administered — combining medicine, mantra, and water — and after a skilled practitioner has examined it, healing is to be performed.

This concludes the second chapter, the chapter of examining all signs, from the tantra of the Glorious Mahāsthāmaprapta.

Now, as for the support that is to be protected: with whatever sequence of procedures it is endowed, the protective wheel is to be composed.

Having performed the approach recitation of the principal deity — ten thousand or one hundred thousand recitations — one then fashions a wheel from gold or silver. Inside it, a complete maṇḍala is to be made, or alternatively a center with eight petals, together with a vajra fence and the like. White mustard and the other five grains, the five precious substances, and the five medicines are to be placed within it, and the consecration is to be performed. When it is fully complete, it is to be bound. Furthermore, using a shroud-cloth from a chariot, a tree's bark, or a charnel ground, the fumigation and the dispelling of obstructors are to be performed in the proper manner. The recitation is the same as described above. When the maṇḍala is fully complete, the mantras too are to be written out in full. By means of the wheel of body, speech, and mind, one is to protect the body, speech, and mind. When it is not fully complete, on six corners the mantras of the six heroes are to be written and contemplated as marking the body of the one to be protected. On the six axillary spokes, the six syllables of the svastika are to be written and contemplated as marking the body of the one to be protected. In the center, the syllable Kṣa is to be written and all obstacles are to be imagined as cleared away. The ritual procedure is to be brought to full completion, and the crafted vessel is to be changed in color. Well concealed, it is to be bound at the crown of the head, or similarly at the throat, at the shoulder, at the brahma-aperture, at the enjoyment level, or four finger-widths away. Furthermore, for the protection of a patient or a yogin at the level of speech: first, spirits are to be expelled and fumigation performed, and at three places three bindus are to be set with three mantras. Furthermore, at thirty-seven places bindus are to be made and the mantras set. Then the armor and its signs are to be understood as fittingly concordant. Then on a seat or bedding, the mantra Om Āḥ Vajra Rakṣa Rakṣa Hūṃ Phaṭ is to be contemplated or also written. Furthermore, with the right hand, saffron is applied to the palm, and with the left thumb wrathful gesture, one is to nurture well — with mantra — the crown, forehead, ears, eyes, nose, mouth, throat, shoulders, heart-center, navel, the two lower vessels, and the limbs. Furthermore, a five-colored thread, when accompanied by mantra, becomes a protection.

This concludes the third chapter, the chapter on the protective wheel, from the tantra of the Glorious Mahāsthāmaprapta.

Homage to the Protector endowed with great compassion. Vajragarbha again inquired of that very one: "In such a protective wheel as this, what exactly are the distinctions of wisdom?" The Blessed One declared: "The distinctions of suchness through wisdom are to be clearly explained. The abiding places of wisdom are to be understood as being of five kinds: outer, inner, secret, utterly secret, and the great secret. I shall explain them — listen well. The outer wisdom is connected with the color of the body and the hand emblems. Realizing it thus is outer wisdom. Inner wisdom is realizing the aggregates and so forth as the deity. Wisdom free from that very realization is the wisdom of suchness. Then secret wisdom is realized through the channels, winds, and bindus. That which is free from that realization is declared to be the wisdom of secrecy. The bliss free from supreme joy and the bliss of innate co-emergence — the conceptualization of them as bliss is conceptual thought. Abandoning that is the utterly secret wisdom. Then the four great wisdoms: the first is the wisdom of the equanimity of taste that is free from extremes. In that very suchness, one abandons conceptual thought and rests in it accordingly. That suchness is great self-awareness — that very suchness is the great wisdom. If one knows it thus, one will assuredly attain the ground of the vajra-holder."

This concludes the fourth chapter, the chapter on examining wisdom, from the tantra of the Glorious Mahāsthāmaprapta.

Now the examination of that very great wisdom is to be explained. The first is the equanimity of taste. In the equanimity of taste of emptiness, all things whatsoever — colors of the body and hand emblems, aggregates, elements, and sense sources, channels, winds, and bindus, joy and supreme joy free from that, and all the rest — are to be known as mere illusion. That very thing is called the awareness of the other.

To meditate on the suchness of self-aware mind
as utterly non-dual —
that is the great primordial wisdom:
the examination brought to its ultimate completion.

This concludes the fifth chapter, the chapter on examining great primordial wisdom, from the tantra of the Glorious Mahāsthāmaprapta.

Thus, when the Blessed One had spoken, Vajragarbha and all the other heroes, ḍākinīs, yoginīs, and the assembly of the māmākīs rejoiced and were filled

with delight. They made offerings with outer, inner, and secret offerings, circumambulated three times to the left, and then vanished from sight.

Translator's Notes

- The text opens mid-sentence with "and was translated by the translator-monk Śākya Ye shes," indicating this passage follows a colophon from a preceding text; the translation begins where the Tibetan begins.

The phrase rendered as "the bhaga of the consort" is a technical Tantric term referring to the female consort's generative center as a sacred locus of Tantric practice; the Tibetan "འཇམ་མཁའ་ལྷ་མོ་" preserves the Sanskrit loanword "bhaga" directly.

"Lāmā" here appears to refer to a class of ḍākinī rather than a teacher, as the Tibetan "ལྷ་མོ་" in this context names a specific category within the ḍākinī assembly.

The final verse-line about wind destroying a lamp is clearly incomplete in the source, breaking off mid-simile; what would follow is the teaching that, just as wind destroys a lamp, the "wind" of a certain practice destroys something analogous.

- The title rendered as "the tantra of the Glorious Mahāsthāmaprapta" translates Dpal Stobs po che, which literally means "the Glorious Great Power" or "the Glorious Mighty One." This is a standard Tibetan rendering of the bodhisattva Mahāsthāmaprapta, though in a tantric context it can also refer simply to "the tantra of the Glorious Mighty One" as a titular epithet rather than a specific bodhisattva name. The identification with Mahāsthāmaprapta is standard in the tradition but worth noting.

The phrase translated as "illusory woman" refers to a tantric consort or visualized female figure used as a means to realize non-dual awareness; the doctrinal warning that follows — about falling into the great hells if the profound conduct is practiced without understanding the profound intent — is a standard Vajrayāna caution about the danger of misapplying such methods.

- The phrase rendered "brahma-aperture" translates Tibetan tshangs pa'i bu ga, the aperture at the crown of the skull through which consciousness is said to exit at death; this is a standard tantric anatomical term (Sanskrit brahmarandhra).

The rendering "six heroes" for dpa' bo drug follows the tantric usage of six vīras as wrathful protective deities associated with the six directions or six spokes of a wheel; the exact identities vary by tradition and are not specified in this passage.

The phrase "at the enjoyment level" for longs spyod mnyam is somewhat elliptical in the source; it likely refers to the saṃbhogakāya level or a corresponding point on the body used in tantric practice. The precise anatomical or doctrinal referent is not made explicit here.

The final phrase "awareness of the other" for gzhan rig is a technical Vajrayāna term; the passage breaks off mid-explanation, so its full definition would have followed in the continuation.

- The circumambulation direction "to the left" is notable: in tantric contexts, leftward circumambulation can carry specific ritual significance distinct from the usual rightward pradakṣiṇā, though some texts use it in particular maṇḍala or wrathful deity contexts. This rendering follows the Tibetan literally.

The term མ་མཁའ་ (māmakī) here appears in the plural as a class of female tantric beings associated with wrathful or semi-wrathful assemblies; "māmakīs" is used as the most precise

rendering, since the Tibetan uses the collective noun form.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.